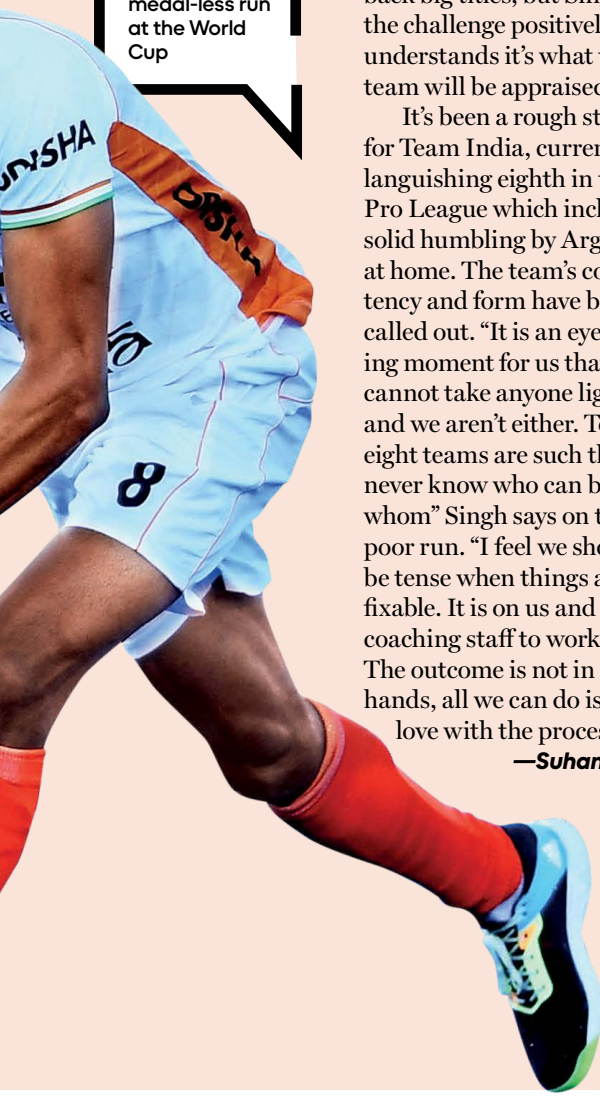


FLAG'S GLORY
At stake now is the quest to end India's 50-year medal-less run at the World Cup

AFP

one is waiting for a win." It's a tall order to win back-to-back big titles, but Singh sees the challenge positively and understands it's what the team will be appraised for.

It's been a rough start for Team India, currently languishing eighth in the Pro League which included a solid humbling by Argentina at home. The team's consistency and form have been called out. "It is an eye-opening moment for us that we cannot take anyone lightly and we aren't either. Top eight teams are such that you never know who can beat whom" Singh says on the poor run. "I feel we should be tense when things are not fixable. It is on us and on the coaching staff to work on it. The outcome is not in our hands, all we can do is fall in love with the process." ■

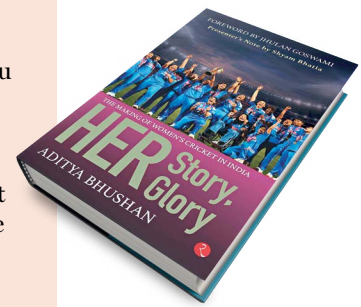
—Suhani Singh

BOOKS ▼

Women at Play

Aditya Bhushan's *Her Story, Her Glory* is a timely history of women's cricket in India

They call it the gentlemen's game, which is perhaps why it took 57 years for the first women's Test cricket match to take place—in 1934 in Brisbane, between Australia and England—after the men from the two countries had played their first Test match in 1877. We did not fare any better—the Indian women's team's debut similarly came in 1976, while their male counterparts had already opened their innings at Lord's in 1932, 44 years prior to them.



HER STORY, HER GLORY
By Aditya Bhushan
RUPA
₹495; 272 pages

For an unduly long span of time, women's cricket did not receive the attention or respect it deserved, especially in India. All that started to change exactly two decades ago, when the Women's Cricket Association of India was merged into the BCCI in 2006. They finally had proper funds and the world was watching.

Cricket writer Aditya Bhushan's *Her Story, Her Glory*—I'm guessing, commissioned after our spectacular World Cup win in November last year, when we beat South Africa by 52 runs—is a timely, well-researched and digestible history of women's cricket in India. It may have been late to bloom, but Indian women's cricket has well and truly found its rightful spot in the world of sport today. ■

—Amit Dixit



currently president of the Indian Rugby Football Union. With the Indian women's team ranked higher (sixth) than the men's in Asia (12th), it seems fair that they get the spotlight.

If it were up to Bose, he'd have had the women's edition from the inception, for gender parity is central to Rugby India's functioning. The organisation pays its women's and men's team players



"I HAVE ALWAYS DREAMT **OF WHEN INDIA'S BEST WILL PLAY WITH THE WORLD'S BEST," SAYS RAHUL BOSE,** ACTOR, FORMER PLAYER AND PRESIDENT OF THE INDIAN RUGBY FOOTBALL UNION

the same and provides them the same infrastructure and facilities. Bose is very confident of the impact. "I know that the moment the first Indian woman, one from the heart of India's tribal belt, tackles somebody from one of the top rugby-playing nations of the world, something transformative is going to happen," he says.

Within the four women's teams, there are countless inspiring tales. Rima Oroan from West Bengal's Saraswatipur is the daughter of tea garden labourers, while Vaishnavi's father, an auto rickshaw driver, once against her playing is now her biggest supporter. "Girls who come on to the rugby field are fighting to prove something off the field," notes Bose. The league itself will also be a great training ground for the national team for the upcoming Asian Games. ■

—Suhani Singh